

THE ADHD NOTION RECOVERY GUIDE

FOCUS DOCK

Stop the setup spiral. Start doing.

DO THIS NEXT

Put 3 dishes in the sink



Everything else stays hidden until this is done.

3 databases — not 14

One visible task

No streak shame

A recovery protocol for everyone who abandoned
yet another Notion template — install a working
3-database system in one sitting.

5 SECTIONS · READ ONLY WHAT YOU NEED

CONTENTS

Five sections. Do Sections 1–4 in order, at your own pace. Keep Section 5 for looking things up. Page numbers below so you can jump straight in.

§	Section	What's in it	Page
1	Start Here	Pick your path + a 30-second self-check	3
2	The 5-Minute Win	One real task done before you touch Notion	6
3	The Install	Build the 3-database system in one sitting — 5 steps	9
4	Daily Use	The daily rhythm, task sequences, Sunday reset, recovery	21
5	Reference	R-1 to R-16 lookup: formulas, fixes, printables, FAQ	31

Worth bookmarking: copy-paste formulas (R-1, p. 32) · troubleshooting (R-6, p. 35) · printable emergency card (R-8, p. 38).

Sections 1–4 are things you **do**, in order, at your own pace. Section 5 is a reference you **look things up in** later. The whole guide is built from the same four boxes, so you always know what you're looking at:

- **ANCHOR** — where you are, how long it takes, and what "done" looks like
- **DO THIS NOW** — the exact actions, numbered — nothing extra
- **CHECKPOINT** — a quick test that proves it worked before you move on
- **! IF YOU DRIFT** — the way back when attention wanders — no shame

>>

Don't read cover to cover. Pick a section. Stop at its checkpoint.

SECTION 1 OF 5

START HERE

Two pages. Then you pick a section and go.

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 1 → Reading map

TIME: 1 min

WIN: You know which section to enter and when to stop reading.

SKIP IF: You already finished the install — jump to Section 4.

Don't read this cover to cover. Pick a section. Stop when you hit a checkpoint.

If you...	Go to	Timer
Need proof this is for you	Section 1 → Self-check	1 min
Want a win RIGHT NOW	Section 2 — 5-Minute Win	5 min
Are ready to build	Section 3 — Install	one sitting
Already installed	Section 4 — Daily Use	3 min
Something broke / are drowning	Section 4 → Emergency, or Section 5 → R-6	4 min
Are looking something up	Section 5 — Reference (R-1 to R-16)	skim

>>

Default path: Self-check → 5-Minute Win → Install → one visible task → close Notion.

DO THIS NOW

1. Pick your section from the table above.
2. Open only that section.
3. Close the PDF when you hit its checkpoint.

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 1 → Self-check

TIME: 30 sec

WIN: You know if Focus Dock is for you.

You need this guide if...

- ☐ You've abandoned 2+ Notion templates in the past year
- ☐ You've spent 3+ hours setting up before doing one real task
- ☐ You have habit trackers with broken streaks you avoid looking at
- ☐ 'Do laundry' or 'email boss' has sat on your list for 5+ days
- ☐ You feel productive while customizing but not while working

Skip this guide if...

- ☐ You already use Notion daily without thinking about it
- ☐ You enjoy building systems as a hobby (separate from productivity)
- ☐ You have a coach or assistant who manages your task list

CHECKPOINT

✓ 3+ checks in 'need this'? → Section 2

✓ 0–2 checks? This guide may not be your bottleneck

Stuck? → Section 5 → R-13 FAQ

! IF YOU DRIFT

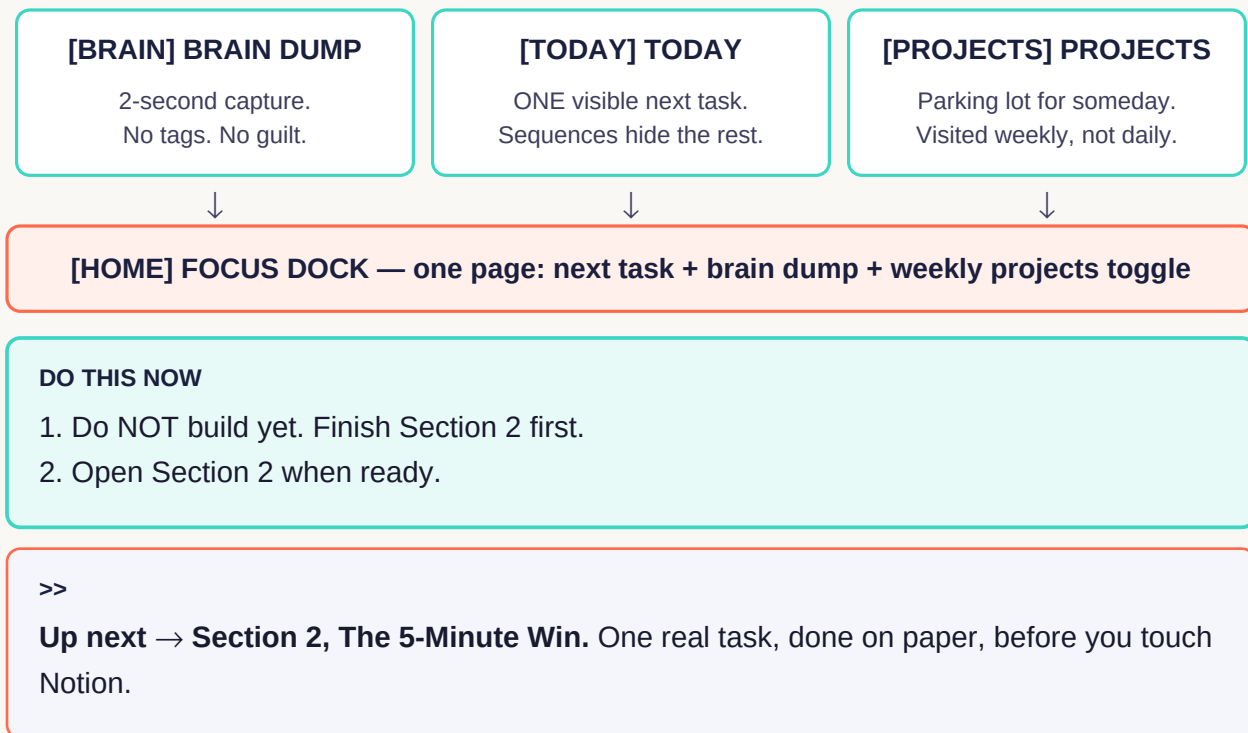
Noticed yourself reading the FAQ before doing anything?

→ Section 2 first. The FAQ is R-13. Win before walls of text.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **Section 2 — 5-Minute Win**.

What you'll build (preview only)

Three databases and one home screen. That's the whole system.



THE 5-MINUTE WIN

One real task done before you touch Notion. Proof first.

Before you build anything, you'll finish one real task — on paper. It takes about five minutes and proves the method works before you spend a whole sitting installing it. If it feels too easy, good. Easy is the point.

The one-task rule

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 2 → One-task rule

TIME: 1 min

WIN: You picked one avoided task.

Twelve databases = twelve decisions before breakfast. Your brain is already tired.

We're cutting that to **one visible task**. Notion comes later. Task completion comes now.

DO THIS NOW

1. Name one task you've avoided for 3+ days.
2. Write it on paper — not in Notion.
3. Say it out loud once.

Shrink it small

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 2 → Shrink task

TIME: 1 min

WIN: Your task is small enough to start.

Laundry → put 3 items in the hamper.

Email boss → open a draft.

Clean kitchen → put 3 dishes in the sink.

DO THIS NOW

1. Rewrite YOUR task as the smallest version.
2. If it still feels too big, shrink it again.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Could you do the shrunk version right now?

Stuck? → Shrink again — smaller is better

Do it on paper (no Notion yet)

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 2 → Do the task

TIME: 2–3 min

WIN: One real task finished.

DO THIS NOW

1. Put your phone in another room.
2. Do the shrunk task now.
3. Mark a check on the paper when done.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Task done — or you tried and stopped

Stuck? → Section 4 → Emergency

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself customizing your phone's notes app?

→ Defaults are fine. A sticky note works.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **the tiny task on paper**.

Bridge to install

>>

You just did the hard part. Starting beats any dashboard. Notion only holds the task — you already proved you can finish one.

When you're ready: Section 3 — Install. Same one-task energy, one sitting.

DO THIS NOW

1. Block 45–60 quiet minutes for the install.
2. Phone in another room. Open Notion only.

>>

Up next → Section 3, The Install. Five steps, one sitting, everything spelled out.

THE INSTALL

One sitting, about 45–60 minutes. Five steps. Zero philosophy.

This section walks the whole build, start to finish, in five steps. Each step says exactly what to click, roughly how long it takes, and how to check that it worked. Follow the boxes in order and you can't get lost — every step also names its rescue page in the Reference section.

Before you start

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Before you start

TIME: 2 min

WIN: You know the rules before building.

SKIP IF: Already installed → Section 4

This is not a template to admire. It is a **recovery protocol**. Theory waits until Section 4.

What you need

- A Notion account (the free plan works)
- One uninterrupted sitting — phone in another room
- Permission to quarantine your template graveyard

>>

RULE ZERO: Urge to add a 4th database? **Setup spiral**. Close Notion. Do one real task.

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself watching Notion tutorial videos?

→ Close YouTube. Open R-2 (UI Map). Find the button.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **Step 1 — Quarantine the graveyard**.

Step 1 — Quarantine the graveyard

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Step 1 of 5

TIME: ~5 min

WIN: Old templates out of sight, not deleted.

Why this comes first: while the old dashboards sit one click away, your attention keeps leaking back into them. Quarantine isn't tidying — it's removing the relapse trigger.

DO THIS NOW

1. Open the Notion sidebar. Count your productivity-related pages.
2. If more than 5: create a page titled **[GRAVEYARD] Template Graveyard**.
3. Drag every abandoned dashboard, habit tracker, and PARA clone into it. Do not open them.
4. Collapse the graveyard page.

You are not deleting anything — you're quarantining shame. Everything stays retrievable.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Sidebar shows 5 or fewer productivity pages

Stuck? → R-10 Migration Checklist

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself opening old dashboards 'one last time'?

→ Don't open. Drag away. Curiosity is a trap.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **Step 2 — Brain Dump**.

Step 2 — Build [BRAIN] Brain Dump

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Step 2 of 5

TIME: ~10 min

WIN: A 2-second capture inbox exists.

Brain Dump exists so stray thoughts have somewhere to go that isn't your head — and isn't your task list. It stays deliberately bare: three properties means capture takes two seconds and organizing is impossible.

DO THIS NOW

1. New page → type **/database** → choose **Database — Full page**. Name it **[BRAIN] Brain Dump**.
2. Rename the default title property to **Thought**.
3. Add property: **Captured** (Created time — fills itself).
4. Add property: **Processed?** (Checkbox).
5. Delete every other property. Yes, all of them.
6. Create a view named **Inbox**: filter **Processed? is unchecked**, sort **Captured ascending**.

>>

Usage rule: capture in 2 seconds. Thought only. No tags. Process during the Sunday reset or when Today is empty.

CHECKPOINT

- ✓ Add a test thought — it appears in Inbox
 - ✓ Delete the test thought
- Stuck?** → R-2 Notion UI Quick Map

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself adding tags, categories, or priority properties?
→ Brain Dump has 3 properties. That's the feature.
→ Still in this section? Skip to **Step 3 — Today**.

Step 3 — Build [TODAY] Today + sequences

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Step 3 of 5

TIME: ~15 min

WIN: One visible next task, powered by sequence logic.

This is the heart of the system and the longest step. You'll add plain properties first, then two roll-ups, then two formulas, then one view — in that order, because each piece depends on the one before it.

DO THIS NOW

1. New page → **/database** → **Database — Full page**. Name it **[TODAY] Today**.
2. Keep the title property. Rename it **Task**.
3. Add **Done** (Checkbox), **Due** (Date), and **Energy** (Select with options: **[HIGH] High / [MED] Medium / [LOW] Low**).

The sequence relation

1. Add property → **Relation** → pick this same **Today** database.
2. Turn ON **Separate directions** (this creates a paired property).
3. Name the first direction **Task Before** and the paired one **Task After**.

Two roll-ups (create these before the formulas)

- **Before Done** — Rollup: relation **Task Before** → property **Done** → Calculate: **Checked** (count of checked).
- **Before Due** — Rollup: relation **Task Before** → property **Due** → Calculate: **Latest date**.

Two formulas (copy from this page)

Add a **Formula** property named **Hide Sequence**. Paste:

```
if(empty(prop("Task Before")), false, if(prop("Before Done") > 0, false, if(prop("Due") < prop("Before Due"), false, true)))
```

Add a second **Formula** property named **Hide**. Paste:

```
prop("Hide Sequence")
```

Full formula breakdown + troubleshooting live in **R-1**. You don't need to understand them now.

The Do This Next view

1. Create a view named **Do This Next**.
2. Filters: **Hide is unchecked** AND **Done is unchecked**.
3. Sort: **Due ascending**.

>>

This view is your entire daily driver. One task visible. Everything else is hidden by sequence logic.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Add test task 'Put 3 dishes in sink' — it shows in Do This Next

Stuck? → R-1 Formulas / R-6 Troubleshooting

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself trying gallery views and card previews?

→ Aesthetic trap. A plain table works. Defaults until Day 8.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **Step 4 — Projects**.

Step 4 — Build [PROJECTS] Projects

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Step 4 of 5

TIME: ~5 min

WIN: A parking lot for someday — out of your daily view.

Projects is where 'someday' lives so it stops haunting your daily view. You'll only open it during the Sunday reset.

DO THIS NOW

1. New page → **/database** → **Database — Full page**. Name it **[PROJECTS] Projects**.
2. Properties: **Name** (Title), **Status** (Select: [IDEA] Idea / [ACTIVE] Active / [PAUSED] Paused / [DONE] Done), **Next Action** (Text).
3. Create a view named **Active**: filter **Status = Active**. Drag what matters to the top.

You do NOT work from this database daily. During the Sunday reset, pick one Next Action and move it to Today.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Projects exists with exactly 3 properties

Stuck? → R-3 Property Reference

Step 5 — Build the [HOME] home screen

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 3 → Step 5 of 5

TIME: ~10 min

WIN: Open Notion → see one task. No sidebar maze.

This page is what makes the system feel effortless: open Notion, see one task, do it. No sidebar spelunking.

DO THIS NOW

1. New page: **[HOME] Focus Dock**.
2. Add a heading: **Right now**:
3. Type **/linked** → link the **Do This Next** view from Today (embedded view, not the full database).
4. Add a heading: **Brain dump (2 sec)**: → /linked → the Brain Dump **Inbox** view.
5. Add a toggle: **Projects (Sunday only)** → put the linked **Active** view inside it.
6. Drag **[HOME] Focus Dock** to the top of your sidebar, and in Settings set Notion to open on the top page in your sidebar (search Settings for 'Open on start').

CHECKPOINT

- ✓ Opening Notion lands on [HOME] Focus Dock
- ✓ Exactly one task is visible under 'Right now'

Stuck? → R-2 Notion UI Quick Map

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself reorganizing your whole sidebar?

→ Only [HOME] matters. The rest can stay messy.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **Finish the install (next box)**.

Finish — do one real task

DO THIS NOW

1. Add one real task to Today — something you've actually avoided.
2. Do it now, before closing this guide.
3. Mark it Done. Close Notion.

>>

Done. You installed a working system AND completed a real task in one sitting. That's more than any template ever gave you.

Install checklist (1 of 2)

Steps 1–24: quarantine, Brain Dump, and Today. Follow in order during your first install. If a step takes longer than expected, keep going — do not add unlisted features.

>>

Stuck? Skip aesthetics. Defaults are fine. Good enough beats perfect.

Step	Action
1	Phone in another room. Open Notion on desktop or in a browser only.
2	Sidebar audit: count productivity pages. If 5+, create the [GRAVEYARD] Template Graveyard page.
3	Drag abandoned dashboards into the graveyard. Do NOT open them. Collapse the graveyard.
4	Create a new page: [BRAIN] Brain Dump. Type /database → Database — Full page.
5	Rename the title property to Thought. Delete all other default properties.
6	Add Captured (Created time). Add Processed? (Checkbox).
7	Create the Inbox view. Filter: Processed? unchecked. Sort: Captured ascending.
8	Test capture: add 'test thought'. Confirm it appears in Inbox. Delete the test.
9	Create the page [TODAY] Today. /database → Database — Full page.
10	Add Task (title), Done (checkbox), Due (date), Energy (select).
11	Energy options: [HIGH] High, [MED] Medium, [LOW] Low.
12	Add a relation to Today itself. Turn ON Separate directions.
13	Name the directions Task Before and Task After.
14	Add the Before Done rollup: Task Before → Done → Calculate: Checked.
15	Add the Before Due rollup: Task Before → Due → Calculate: Latest date.
16	Add the Hide Sequence formula property (copy from R-1).
17	Add the Hide formula: prop("Hide Sequence").
18	Create the Do This Next view. Filters: Hide unchecked, Done unchecked.
19	Sort Do This Next by Due ascending. This is your daily driver.
20	Add a test task 'Put 3 dishes in sink'. Confirm it shows in Do This Next.
21	Create the page [PROJECTS] Projects. /database → Database — Full page.

Step	Action
22	Add Name, Status (Idea/Active/Paused/Done), Next Action (text).
23	Create the Active view: Status = Active. Manual sort enabled.
24	Add one project with Next Action text only. Do not add tasks here.

Install checklist (2 of 2)

Steps 25–48: Projects, home screen, and the first real task.

Step	Action
25	Create the page [HOME] Focus Dock. This becomes your home base.
26	Add heading: Right now. Embed the linked Do This Next view from Today.
27	Add heading: Brain dump. Embed the linked Inbox view from Brain Dump.
28	Add toggle: Projects (Sunday only). Embed the Active view inside it.
29	Drag [HOME] Focus Dock to the top of the sidebar. In Settings, set 'Open on start' to top page in sidebar.
30	Close every other Notion tab. Only Focus Dock remains.
31	Add your first real task to Today. Not a test — something you've avoided.
32	If the task is big: stop. Break it into a 3-step sequence with Task Before links.
33	Verify only step 1 is visible in Do This Next. Steps 2–3 hidden.
34	Move up to 3 items from old notes into Brain Dump, if any. Max 3.
35	Review Projects: max 1 Active for week one. Pause the others.
36	Delete any extra views you created during setup. Keep only the essentials.
37	Do NOT change colors, icons, or covers. Aesthetic trap — defaults are fine.
38	Read the R-8 emergency card once. Bookmark it mentally.
39	Screenshot your Focus Dock home — a private before/after record. Don't post it.
40	Write on paper: 'One task is enough.' Tape it near your desk.
41	Calendar: add a recurring Sunday reset reminder.
42	Do the one visible task NOW, before closing this guide.
43	Mark it Done. Watch the next sequence step appear (if it has one).
44	If nothing appears next: pull one item from Brain Dump into Today.
45	Close Notion. Do not reopen it until tomorrow morning.
46	One sentence on paper: what made starting hard today?
47	Save this PDF somewhere findable. Name it: Focus Dock Recovery.
48	You recovered. The graveyard can wait.

>>

Done when: one task visible in Do This Next, one task marked Done, Notion closed.

>>

Up next → **Section 4, Daily Use.** The 3-minute rhythm that keeps this system alive.



DAILY USE

Life after install: the 3-minute rhythm, sequences, resets, recovery.

The system is built. This section is how you live with it: the 3-minute daily rhythm, what to do when a big task freezes you, the short weekly reset, and how to recover on the loud days.

Daily workflow

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Daily workflow

TIME: 3 min/day

WIN: You know the morning/evening rhythm.

The whole day runs on one loop: open, do the one visible task, capture anything that pops up, close. Here's what that looks like at each point of the day.

Morning

1. Open [HOME] Focus Dock.
2. Read the one task in Do This Next.
3. Do it before opening email, Slack, or TikTok.

During the day

- Intrusive thought? → Brain Dump. One line. Close.
- Finished a task? → Check Done. The next sequence step appears automatically.

Evening

- If Today is empty: pull ONE task from Brain Dump or Projects.
- Do NOT rebuild your dashboard. Do NOT add properties. Go to bed.

>>

If you did nothing else today but open Focus Dock once and complete one task: **system success.**

CHECKPOINT

✓ You can describe the daily flow from memory

Stuck? → R-4 When to Use What

Task sequences — when big tasks freeze you

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Sequences

TIME: 5 min to learn

WIN: Big tasks become one small visible step.

Big tasks are lying to you. 'Do laundry' is 8 tasks. 'Make a video' is 14. When all 8 show at once, your brain files them under 'not now.'

How sequences work

Link tasks with the Task Before / Task After relation. The Hide Sequence formula hides step 2 until step 1 is done. You only ever see the next physical action.

Example: Laundry (6 steps)

1. Collect dirty clothes → 2. Check gym bag → 3. Start washer → 4. Move to dryer → 5. Fold → 6. Put away — each linked with Task Before to the previous one

Example: Email boss (4 steps)

1. Open last week's draft → 2. Write 3 bullet points only → 3. Read it aloud once → 4. Hit send

Example: Grocery run (6 steps)

1. Check fridge → 2. Write a 5-item list max → 3. Grab bags → 4. Drive/walk → 5. Buy only list items → 6. Unload 3 items

Example: Taxes (one sitting)

1. Find login → 2. Download one form → 3. Fill name/address → 4. One deduction section → 5. Save draft → 6. Schedule a finish date

>>

Rule: break steps down until the next one feels 'too small to fail.' If you still can't start, break it again.

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself building a 14-step video sequence?

→ Max 6 steps today. Break more later.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **the Laundry example above**.

Task sequence library

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Sequence library

TIME: pick one: 5 min

WIN: One pre-built sequence copied into Today.

Copy these into the Today database. Link each step to the previous one with Task Before. Rename steps to fit your life.

Sequence	Steps (link each with Task Before)
CLEAN KITCHEN	1. Put 3 dishes in sink · 2. Fill sink with soapy water · 3. Scrub · 4. Rinse · 5. Load dishwasher · 6. Wipe counter · 7. Take out trash · 8. Sweep
EMAIL BOSS	1. Open draft · 2. Write 3 bullets only · 3. Read aloud · 4. Fix typos · 5. Send
CHANGE SHEETS	1. Strip pillowcases · 2. Strip sheets · 3. Hamper · 4. New fitted sheet · 5. New flat sheet · 6. Pillowcases on
YOUTUBE VIDEO	1. Pick topic · 2. Outline 5 bullets · 3. Write script · 4. Set up camera · 5. Record · 6. Transfer files · 7. Rough cut · 8. Thumbnail · 9. Upload · 10. Description + tags
REFILL RX	1. Check bottle date · 2. Call pharmacy · 3. Confirm insurance · 4. Wait for ready text · 5. Drive/walk · 6. Pick up · 7. Weekly organizer
ROOM RESCUE	1. Trash bag in hand · 2. Pick up 5 items · 3. Put away 3 items · 4. Clear one surface · 5. Stop (done)
GROCERIES	1. Check fridge · 2. 5-item list max · 3. Grab bags · 4. Drive/walk · 5. Buy only list items · 6. Unload 3 items
SHOWER RESET	1. Get towel · 2. Get clean clothes · 3. Start water · 4. Shower · 5. Dry off · 6. Dress · 7. Hang towel
TAXES	1. Find login · 2. Download one form · 3. Name/address · 4. One deduction section · 5. Save draft · 6. Schedule finish date
CALL MOM	1. Write 2 topics · 2. Find quiet spot · 3. Dial · 4. Talk briefly · 5. Set next call date

Sequence	Steps (link each with Task Before)
WORKOUT	1. Put on shoes · 2. Fill water · 3. Short warmup · 4. Main exercise · 5. Cooldown · 6. Shower

>>

Pre-build sequences on a good day. Reuse them forever. This is where your dopamine investment goes — not color palettes.

DO THIS NOW

1. Pick ONE sequence on a good day.
2. Copy it into Today with Task Before links.

Sunday reset

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Sunday reset

TIME: ~10 min, hard stop at 15

WIN: Week prepped without a guilt dashboard.

No guilt weekly review. No streak accounting. Three quick passes, then stop.

Pass 1 — Brain Dump triage (~4 min)

- Open Inbox. For each item: delete it, move it to Today, or write it into a Projects Next Action.
- Check Processed? on handled items.

Pass 2 — Today prep (~4 min)

- Clear Done tasks (archive or delete — your choice).
- Keep 3–5 tasks max for the week, sequenced where needed.
- Pick Monday's first task. Set Due = Monday.

Pass 3 — Projects glance (~2 min)

- Open Active projects. Max 3 Active at once — pause the rest.
- Update one Next Action per active project.

>>

At 15 minutes, stop even if unfinished. Consistency beats completeness.

CHECKPOINT

✓ Reset done (or stopped at the hard stop)

Stuck? → R-7 printable checklist

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself the reset stretching past 15 minutes?

→ Stop here. An incomplete reset beats a skipped one.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **R-7 printable checklist**.

Emergency overwhelm protocol

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Emergency

TIME: 4 min

WIN: You survived overwhelm with one tiny action.

For days when everything feels loud. A printable version is **R-8** — print it and tape it to your monitor.

>>

OVERWHELM MODE — do only these 4 steps:

1. **Box breathing:** 4 seconds in, 4 hold, 4 out. Twice.
2. **Brain dump 3 words** — not sentences. What's loudest?
3. **Shrink to the smallest version:** 'clean kitchen' → 'put 3 dishes in the sink.'
4. **Do the smallest version.** Mark done. Stop. You survived.

Do NOT: reorganize Notion, watch setup videos, download a new template, or redesign colors. That is the trap.

When to skip Notion entirely

If you haven't opened Focus Dock in 5+ days: use a sticky note for one task. Return to Notion only when the sticky note works 2 days straight.

Days 2–7 playbook

Install day is Day 1. Days 2–7 are survival mode — no rebuilding, no tutorials, no new views.

Day	Your only job
Day 2	Open [HOME] Focus Dock only. Complete one task. No new properties. Brain dump max 2 captures.
Day 3	Same as Day 2. If the task feels big, split it into a 3-step sequence. Do not add a 4th database.
Day 4	If Do This Next is empty, pull one item from Brain Dump into Today. Still one visible task.
Day 5	Midweek check: count your open Notion tabs. Target = 1 (Focus Dock). Close the rest.
Day 6	Optional: add one pre-built sequence from the Sequence Library (Section 4). Max one new sequence this week.
Day 7	First Sunday reset (~10 min, stop at 15). Stop even if it's messy.

>>

Success metric: you opened Focus Dock and finished one task. Total Notion time under 10 minutes a day.

Week 1–4 rollout

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Week rollout

TIME: 2 min

WIN: You know what each week adds.

Week 1: Survival mode

- Day 1: install only. No customization.
- Days 2–7: one task per day minimum. Brain dump only when a thought intrudes.
- Banned: adding properties, new views, watching Notion tutorials.

Week 2: Add sequences

- Pick your most-delayed task. Break it into a sequence.
- Add a 2nd sequence only after the first one works 3 times.

Week 3: Sunday reset habit

- First full Sunday reset. Stop at 15 minutes even if messy.
- If you skip it: no catch-up. Next Sunday, fresh start.

Week 4: Evaluate

Ask: am I opening Focus Dock without dread? If yes: success. If no: delete one more feature — the system is still too complex.

>>

The 3-week test: systems that survive 21 days become automatic. You're building automatic.

Maintenance — anti-rebuild rules

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Maintenance

TIME: 2 min

WIN: You know what you may change, and when.

Allowed changes (after Day 8)

- Adjust the Energy labels
- Add ONE filter to Do This Next
- Change the homepage label

Banned until Day 30

- Habit trackers
- Mood logs
- PARA / Second Brain migrations
- New databases
- Aesthetic overhauls

>>

If you're still using Focus Dock daily without thinking about it — you succeeded. If not, the system is still too complex. Delete one more thing.

! IF YOU DRIFT

Noticed yourself thinking 'just one new view'?

→ Customization trap. Defaults until Day 8.

→ Still in this section? Skip to **R-5 Setup Spiral Red Flags**.

Why your old system failed (optional)

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Context

TIME: 3 min

WIN: You understand why templates failed — without shame.

SKIP IF: Read when curious, not before installing.

You are not lazy. Your old system was designed to produce screenshots, not completed tasks.

1. Dopamine spent on setup

Customizing Notion releases dopamine. By Saturday night the dopamine budget is empty — and no task got done.

2. Choice overload

Typical ADHD templates ship 6+ databases. Every time you open one, you make a dozen micro-decisions before starting anything.

3. Streak shame

Miss one habit day → broken streak → you close the tab and never come back.

>>

The Focus Dock fix: low setup cost, low decision density, and no visible state that punishes missed days.

Accountability without shame

ANCHOR

YOU ARE HERE: Section 4 → Accountability

TIME: 3 min

WIN: External structure without streak mechanics.

ADHD brains respond to external structure, not internal guilt. Use these — no streak counters attached.

Body doubling

- Video call or in-person: both of you work silently on one task.
- No progress reports required — presence is the cue.

Text ping (not a streak)

- One message: 'Opened Focus Dock. Doing [task].'
- No reply needed. No daily obligation. Skip days without explanation.

Environmental cues

- Notion opens on [HOME] Focus Dock (not the sidebar).
- Phone: a Notion widget or bookmark straight to Brain Dump.
- Desk: the R-8 emergency card taped at eye level.

What to avoid

- Habit-streak apps tied to Focus Dock usage.
- Public accountability threads where missed days = shame.
- Reward systems that require perfect weeks.

>>

One completed task beats seven days of dashboard tweaking. Measure completion, not opens.

>>

Up next → Section 5, Reference. Numbered R-1 to R-16 — your lookup for when anything breaks.



REFERENCE

Skimmable lookup. Numbered R-1 to R-16 — jump straight to what you need.

Nothing here is meant to be read in order. When something breaks — or you forget a detail — find the R-number in the index below and jump straight to it.

Quick reference card

Capture: Brain Dump → type the thought → close (2 sec)

Work: [HOME] Focus Dock → Do This Next → one task

Sequence: Task Before relation + Hide Sequence formula

Weekly: Sunday reset (~10 min, hard stop at 15)

Emergency: smallest-step shrink → do it → stop

Homepage: [HOME] Focus Dock — never the sidebar maze

Find it fast

#	Section	#	Section
R-1	Formulas — copy-paste · p. 32	R-9	What to delete from old templates · p. 39
R-2	Notion UI quick map · p. 33	R-10	Migration checklist · p. 39
R-3	Property reference card · p. 33	R-11	Brain dump processing · p. 40
R-4	When to use what · p. 34	R-12	Energy matching (optional) · p. 41
R-5	Setup spiral red flags · p. 34	R-13	FAQ · p. 41
R-6	Troubleshooting · p. 35	R-14	Glossary · p. 42
R-7	Sunday reset checklist (print) · p. 37	R-15	Research notes · p. 42
R-8	Emergency card (print) · p. 38	R-16	You made it · p. 43

Create these as **Formula** properties in the [TODAY] Today database. Names must match exactly — the view filters depend on them.

Hide Sequence

Property name: **Hide Sequence** · Type: Formula

```
if(empty(prop("Task Before")), false, if(prop("Before Done") > 0, false,
if(prop("Due") < prop("Before Due"), false, true)))
```

What it does: hides a sequenced task while its predecessor is unfinished. Tasks with no Task Before always show.

Hide

Property name: **Hide** · Type: Formula

```
prop("Hide Sequence")
```

What it does: pass-through used by the Do This Next view filter (Hide is unchecked). Filter on Hide, not on Hide Sequence directly.

Required roll-ups (create before the formulas)

- **Before Done** — Rollup: relation Task Before → property Done → Calculate: Checked (count of checked)
- **Before Due** — Rollup: relation Task Before → property Due → Calculate: Latest date

Do This Next view

- Filter: Hide is unchecked
- Filter: Done is unchecked
- Sort: Due ascending

>>

If too many tasks show: verify the Hide Sequence formula exists and the view filters on **Hide**, not Hide Sequence.

Lookup while installing. Use this table instead of tutorial videos. (Notion moves menus occasionally — when in doubt, use the search box inside Settings.)

Task	Where in Notion
Create a database	New page → type /database → Database — Full page
Add a property	Open database → + at the right of the header row → pick type
Formula property	Add property → Formula → paste from R-1
Relation (sequences)	Add property → Relation → pick the same database → turn ON Separate directions → name both directions
Rollup	Add property → Rollup → pick relation → pick target property → pick calculation
Filter a view	Click the view name → Filter → add rule (Hide unchecked, Done unchecked)
Embed a linked view	On the [HOME] page → /linked → pick database → pick the view
Open Notion on [HOME]	Drag [HOME] to the top of the sidebar → Settings → search ' Open on start ' → Top page in sidebar

Brain Dump database (3 properties)

- **Thought** (Title) — the capture
- **Captured** (Created time)
- **Processed?** (Checkbox)

Today database (10 properties)

- **Task** (Title)
- **Done** (Checkbox)
- **Due** (Date)
- **Energy** (Select: High / Medium / Low)
- **Task Before** (Relation → Today, separate directions)
- **Task After** (Relation → Today, the paired direction)
- **Before Done** (Rollup: count of checked Done)
- **Before Due** (Rollup: latest Due date)
- **Hide Sequence** (Formula — see R-1)

- **Hide** (Formula — see R-1)

Projects database (3 properties)

- **Name** (Title)
- **Status** (Select: Idea / Active / Paused / Done)
- **Next Action** (Text)

Do This Next view

Filter 1: Hide is unchecked · Filter 2: Done is unchecked · Sort: Due ascending

R-4 When to use what — decision table

If you're unsure where something goes, use this table. A wrong choice is fixable during the Sunday reset.

Situation	Use this	Keep it to
Random thought while working	[BRAIN] Brain Dump — one line, close	2 seconds
What should I do right now?	[HOME] Focus Dock — Do This Next view	90 seconds
Big project with many steps	[TODAY] Today — break into a sequence	6 steps max
Someday idea, not this week	[PROJECTS] Projects — Idea status	Sunday reset only
Overwhelmed, can't start	R-8 emergency card — 2-minute shrink	the smallest step
Sunday weekly prep	R-7 reset checklist	~10 min, stop at 15
Urge to add a 4th database	Close Notion. Do one real task.	now

R-5 Setup spiral red flags

Catch these urges early. Each one feels productive. None of them completes a task.

Red flag	What to do instead
New database idea	You 'just need' a Reading List or Habits database. Use Brain Dump or Projects instead.
Color/icon session	30+ minutes on aesthetics, zero tasks completed. Close Notion.
Tutorial spiral	Watching 'ultimate Notion setup' videos during install week. Banned until Day 30.

Red flag	What to do instead
Filter rabbit hole	Adding a 4th filter to Do This Next. Max one optional filter, and only after Day 8.
Migration fantasy	Planning to merge your old PARA system into Focus Dock. Quarantine the old system instead.
Weekly review creep	The Sunday reset running past 15 minutes. Hard stop — good enough beats perfect.
Streak mechanic	Adding a habit tracker to prove you're consistent. Streaks become shame monuments.
Property sprawl	New properties: Priority, Context, Effort, Mood. Today has enough. Stop.

>>

Ask: 'Will this help me see ONE next task tomorrow?' If no, don't do it.

R-6

Troubleshooting

I keep customizing instead of doing

Set a build budget: zero customizing on weekdays. Changes happen during the Sunday reset only — and count toward its 15-minute stop.

Too many tasks are visible

Check that the Hide formula exists and Do This Next filters on **Hide is unchecked** (see R-1).

Sequences aren't hiding

Confirm Task Before is a relation with separate directions, and the Before Done rollup counts *checked* boxes. Verify each Task Before link points to the correct prior step.

Do This Next is empty but I have tasks

Uncheck Done on active tasks and confirm Due dates exist. In a sequence, make sure step 1 has no Task Before link — otherwise everything hides.

I skipped Brain Dump and my head is loud again

Intrusive thoughts hijack focus. The 2-second capture prevents the 'I'll remember it' lie. Capture, close, keep working.

The Brain Dump inbox never empties

Normal. The inbox is capture, not completion. Process it during the Sunday reset only — never mid-week.

I abandoned it for a week

No guilt dashboard exists here. Delete done tasks, pull ONE item from Brain Dump, continue. Streaks don't exist in Focus Dock.

The Sunday reset keeps running long

Hard stop at 15 minutes. An incomplete reset beats a skipped one.

I want more structure

Read that again. Wanting more structure is often productivity theater wearing a productivity costume. Stay at 3 databases for 30 days first. Already added a 4th? Delete it today — and don't migrate its relations.

Print this page. Check the boxes with a pen during your Sunday reset. Stop at 15 minutes, done or not.

- ☐ Open [BRAIN] Brain Dump Inbox — triage each item (delete / Today / Projects)
- ☐ Mark Processed? on handled Brain Dump items
- ☐ Archive or delete completed Today tasks
- ☐ Today has 3–5 tasks max for the coming week
- ☐ Monday's first task has Due = Monday
- ☐ Max 3 [PROJECTS] Active — pause the rest
- ☐ Each Active project has one written Next Action
- ☐ Did NOT add properties, views, or databases
- ☐ Stopped at 15 minutes (even if unfinished)

>>

An incomplete reset beats a skipped reset. Same time next Sunday — no catch-up guilt.

Print this page. Cut along the dashes. Tape the card to your monitor.

OVERWHELM MODE

1. Box breathe: 4 in · 4 hold · 4 out — twice
2. Brain dump 3 WORDS (not sentences)
3. Shrink the task to its SMALLEST version
4. Do it. Mark done. STOP.

DO NOT: open Notion settings · download templates · reorganize · watch setup videos

AWAY 5+ DAYS? Sticky note with ONE task. Return when the sticky works 2 days straight.

You are not behind. You are not broken. One task is enough.

When quarantining your Template Graveyard, these features stay banned in Focus Dock:

Delete or ignore permanently

- Habit streak counters
- Mood trackers (unless prescribed by your therapist)
- Eisenhower matrices
- PARA 'Areas' and 'Resources' databases
- Weekly review dashboards with 20+ checkboxes
- Journal prompts you never read
- Finance dashboards (your bank's app does this better)

Why each one fails ADHD brains

Streaks: one miss = a shame monument.

PARA: 'Is this a Project or an Area?' = decision paralysis.

Weekly reviews: 45 minutes of facing failure.

Mood logs: evidence you're 'inconsistent.'

>>

If a feature requires daily maintenance to avoid looking broken, delete it.

Do not migrate relations or dashboards. Quarantine and cherry-pick. Keep it short.

- [] Create the [GRAVEYARD] Template Graveyard page
- [] Drag old dashboards, habit trackers, and PARA clones into it
- [] Collapse the graveyard — do not open old pages during install week
- [] Copy max 3 open loops into [BRAIN] Brain Dump (one line each)
- [] Copy max 1 Next Action per real project into [PROJECTS] Projects
- [] Do NOT import CSVs with 200 old tasks
- [] Do NOT recreate Eisenhower matrices, mood logs, or streak views
- [] Set [HOME] Focus Dock as your start page before deleting bookmarks to old dashboards

What to salvage vs leave behind

Salvage: open tasks, project names, one-line next actions.

Leave: relations, rollups, aesthetic layouts, archived 'someday' lists, broken streaks.

>>

A fresh start beats a perfect migration. The old system is quarantined, not deleted — you can retrieve things later if you truly need them.

R-11 Brain dump — processing guide

Brain Dump is capture-only during the week. Processing happens in the Sunday reset or when Today is empty.

The 10-second triage (per item)

1. **Delete** — noise, duplicates, 'someday' ideas you'll never do
2. **Today** — one physical action you could do this week
3. **Projects** — multi-step outcomes; write the Next Action text only

What NOT to do during triage

- Do not tag, categorize, or assign priority
- Do not create sub-pages or linked databases
- Do not keep triaging past your reset's 15-minute stop

When to capture (2 seconds)

- Intrusive thought during focused work
- 'I'll remember this' lie detected
- Someone asks you to do something while you're busy

>>

Capture is not commitment. Processing is not urgent. Today is the only daily driver.

Only use Energy tags if they help. If choosing a level causes paralysis, ignore the property entirely — it's optional by design.

[HIGH] High energy

Creative work, hard conversations, complex sequences, starting new projects.

[MED] Medium energy

Email, errands, admin, routine chores, continuing in-progress work.

[LOW] Low energy

Brain dump triage, tiny tasks, reading one paragraph, putting one item away.

>>

On low days: filter Do This Next by Low energy — or skip the filter and just do the smallest visible task.

Can I use this alongside medication?

Yes. Focus Dock is organizational, not medical. Keep your treatment plan.

What about mobile?

Notion mobile works. Favorite [HOME] Focus Dock, and add a Notion widget for 2-second Brain Dump captures.

Can I share it with my partner?

The license covers one person. Your partner needs their own copy for their own workspace.

Should I use Notion AI with this?

Skip it for now. AI features add decisions. Master the 3-database core first.

Can I migrate from Ultimate Brain / PARA?

Don't migrate. Quarantine the old system (R-10). A fresh start prevents relation nightmares.

What if I need more than 3 databases eventually?

After 30 successful days, add ONE database. Not before. Prove the minimum works first.

R-14

Glossary

Setup spiral: tweaking your system instead of doing the task the system was for.

Template graveyard: the collection of abandoned Notion setups you avoid opening.

Productivity theater: looks productive. Zero tasks finished.

Task sequence: linked sub-tasks where only the next step is visible.

Brain dump: frictionless capture inbox — no organization required.

Choice overload: too many options → paralysis → no action.

Executive dysfunction: knowing what to do but being unable to start it in the moment.

Visible state: dashboard elements that look broken when you skip a day.

R-15

Research notes

Focus Dock's design is informed by:

- Iyengar & Lepper (2000) — more choices reduce action (choice overload)
- Volkow et al. (2009) — ADHD dopamine-pathway differences
- Barkley (2012) — executive function as a performance problem, not a knowledge problem
- Tuckman — externalize executive function into the environment
- Lived experience: setup-spiral threads across r/Notion and r/ADHD

This guide externalizes 'what's next' so your brain doesn't have to hold it.

If you're reading this, you built something most ADHD adults never finish: a system they actually use.

Focus Dock isn't about perfect Notion. It's about **one visible next step** when your brain feels like static.

>>

The whole system fits on a sticky note: **Check → Win → Install → one task → close Notion**. Repeat tomorrow.

Questions? hello@getfocusdock.com · 14-day refund if it doesn't help — no guilt, same as the system.

Now close this PDF and do the one task.